Guide for Developing Course Outlines

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School of
Contemporary Teaching & Learning

St. Lawrence College

Table of Contents

Course Identification 1

Course Description 2

Example Course Description 2

Course Learning Outcomes 3

Example Course Learning Outcomes 3

Strong Learning Outcomes 3

Choosing the Right Verb 4

Common Pitfalls and Related Improvements of CLOs 4

Relationship to Vocational/Program Specific Learning Outcomes 5

Definitions of Foundational, Developing, and Mastery for VLOs/PLOs 6

Foundational 6

Developing 6

Mastery 6

Essential Employability Skills 6

Definitions of Foundational, Developing, and Mastery for Essential Employability Skills 7

Foundational 7

Developing 7

Mastery 7

College Policies and Procedures 7

Guide for Developing Course Outlines

Course Identification

Complete the course identification table.

	Information to Include
Course Name/Code	Enter approved information from Peoplesoft. Contact your School Office or the CCTL for more information.
Program(s)	Enter the program this course is taught in. If it is taught in multiple programs, enter "This course is taught across multiple programs"
Course Hours	Enter the total number of course hours and how those hours are distributed.
Pre-requisites	List the courses students require before taking this course.
Co-requisites	List the courses student are required to take concurrently with this course
PLAR	Indicate if the course is eligible for PLAR (Prior Learning and Assessment Recognition) and by what means that prior learning would be demonstrated.

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Program Context	In 2-4 sentences, explain where the course is situated in the program, including what learning it builds on and towards.
Approval	Upon completion of the Course Outline, send it to appropriate Associate/Campus Dean for approval.

Course Description

The Course Description complements the Course Learning Outcomes and provides students with an overview of the purpose and topics included in the course. It is a single paragraph and approximately 100 words long. Course descriptions:

- use present tense and active voice
- use simple, concise sentences
- use gender-neutral pronouns
- use simple, lay-person's language
- are written from the learner's perspective
- avoid jargon and technical terms that may change over time
- avoid course names, numbers, and levels

Example Course Description

This course introduces students to developmental psychopathology and examines the interaction of genetic, biological, psychological, and behavioural processes in the development of normal and abnormal behaviour from infancy to adolescence. In surveying the major psychological disorders of this period, students learn that many factors relate to the development of troubled behaviour. The course emphasizes proactive and positive strategies for managing and preventing childhood and adolescent behaviour problems. Course content is delivered using a

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lecture/discussion format. In order to enliven concepts and discussions, this course incorporates guest lectures, student presentations, and written case materials.

Course Learning Outcomes

Course Learning Outcomes (CLOs) are measurable, performance-based statements that describe what the learner will be able to do by the end of the course. The CLO section begins with the text "At the conclusion of this course, you will be able to:" The CLOs are listed after this statement and use the following formula:

Do something for a reason or in a given context according to a certain standard or performance criteria.

Example Course Learning Outcomes

Applying the formula above, here are three examples of course learning outcomes that include the

- Design marketing communication materials to meet the advertising needs of clients using industry standard technology.
- Apply theoretical concepts of growth and development when working with individuals and families in the community as required by the public health regulations.
- Describe the significant events in the historical development of the internal combustion engine in terms of their relevance to the development of current and future engines.

Strong Learning Outcomes

As you develop course learning outcomes remember that strong learning outcomes:

- begin with a single, measureable action verb that reflects a level of learning congruent with the position of the course within the program
- are achievable in the time frame of the course
- align with and help students progress towards mastery of the Vocational Learning Outcomes
- are free from jargon and technical language that may change over time
- do not dictate specific assessments, content, or learning activities

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Choosing the Right Verb

In addition to being a measurable and action-oriented, the verb that begins the CLO must reflect a level of learning/performance appropriate to the course's situation with the program. To choose an appropriate verb, refer to the Vocational Learning Outcomes identified for the course (see below). The level (foundational, developing, mastery) will help in understanding the relative level of achievement students in the course should be achieving. In addition, refer to a learning taxonomy (e.g., Bloom's, SOLO, ICE, etc.) for ideas of what verbs reflect differing levels of knowledge and skill.

Common Pitfalls and Related Improvements of CLOs

Pitfall	Requires Improvement	Improved Outcome
Written to reflect specific content	Describe the levels of Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs.	Describe theories of motivation to interpret human behavior in non-stressful situations.
Not written as an outcome but as a goal or a process	Appreciate the importance of personal responsibility in mature human sexuality.	Explain the relationship between personal values and attitudes and mature sexuality.
Not realistic	List the chemical symbol and valencies of all the known elements.	Identify the chemical symbol and valencies of all elements using the periodic table.

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Not verifiable or measurable	Improve your understanding of the laws of electricity.	Use the laws of electricity to explain the viability of particular circuitry in specific applications.
Too narrow; tool specific	Describe the functions of MS Word 2010.	Use word-processing software to prepare reports and correspondence.
Describes a specific assessment	Produce a collection of community resources for promoting positive family functioning.	Select appropriate community resources to promote family functioning.

Relationship to Vocational/Program Specific Learning Outcomes

Vocational or Program Learning Outcomes (VLOs/PLOs) are learning outcomes that describe what a graduate of the program will know and be able to do. For some programs, VLOs are provided by the Ministry of Training, Colleges and Universities. In other cases, PLOs are developed by faculty during initial program development or curriculum mapping.

If the course is part of a program of study, the VLOs/PLOs attached to a particular course were developed by faculty in the curriculum mapping process and cannot be altered. If you are unsure which VLOs your course supports, please contact your Program Coordinator or the CCTL Curriculum team.

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Courses that are part of Local Board Certificates or Statements of Achievement have their own learning outcomes. These are inserted in this section. Check with the Associate/Campus Dean.

Definitions of Foundational, Developing, and Mastery for VLOs/PLOs

Foundational

At this level, faculty introduce concepts and content related to the vocational learning outcomes. Students are not expected to be familiar with the content or skills of the particular field of study at the post-secondary level. Instructional and learning activities focus on basic knowledge, comprehension, skills, attitudes and values at an entry-level complexity that support the learning outcomes. Often, several courses in a curriculum will introduce and reinforce an outcome and provide practice and scaffolding to begin to lay a foundation of achievement. Similarly, some courses may be designed to introduce only one outcome.

Developing

At this level, faculty reinforce and provide opportunities for students to further develop the concepts and content related to the vocational learning outcomes. Instructional and learning activities focus on students beginning to apply and analyze key ideas or skills and are expected to demonstrate their knowledge or ability at increasingly proficient levels necessary for optimal achievement of the vocational learning outcomes in later courses.

Mastery

At this level, faculty continue to reinforce, develop and provide opportunities to integrate all the knowledge, skills, attitudes and values necessary for mastery of the vocational learning outcomes. Instructional and learning activities in the courses focus on using the skills tied to the outcomes in multiple contexts and at mastery level of complexity for the credential level.

Essential Employability Skills

As with the VLOs, the Essential Employability Skills (EESs) have been mapped by faculty in the curriculum mapping phase of the program review cycle. The EESs indicated for your course cannot be changed outside of that process. Please note:

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- If the course is part of a College Graduate Certificate Program, the EES section is not applicable.
- If the course is part of a Local Board Certificate or Statement of Achievement, EESs usually do not apply. Check with the Campus Dean/Associate Dean for exceptions.

Definitions of Foundational, Developing, and Mastery for Essential Employability Skills

Foundational

At this level, faculty introduce concepts related to the Essential Employability Skill. Instructional and learning activities focus on skills at an entry-level complexity to begin to lay a **foundation** of achievement.

Developing

At this level, faculty reinforce and provide opportunities for students to further **develop** the concepts related to the Essential Employability Skill. Instructional and learning activities focus on students beginning to apply the skills and are expected to demonstrate their ability at increasingly proficient levels.

Mastery

At this level, faculty continue to reinforce, develop and provide opportunities to integrate all the skills necessary for **mastery** of the Essential Employability Skill. Instructional and learning activities focus on using the skill in multiple contexts and at mastery level of complexity for the credential level.

College Policies and Procedures

This section is drawn from the Academic Policy Manual and cannot be altered.

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